



National Significant Wildland Fire Potential Outlook

Predictive Services
National Interagency Fire Center

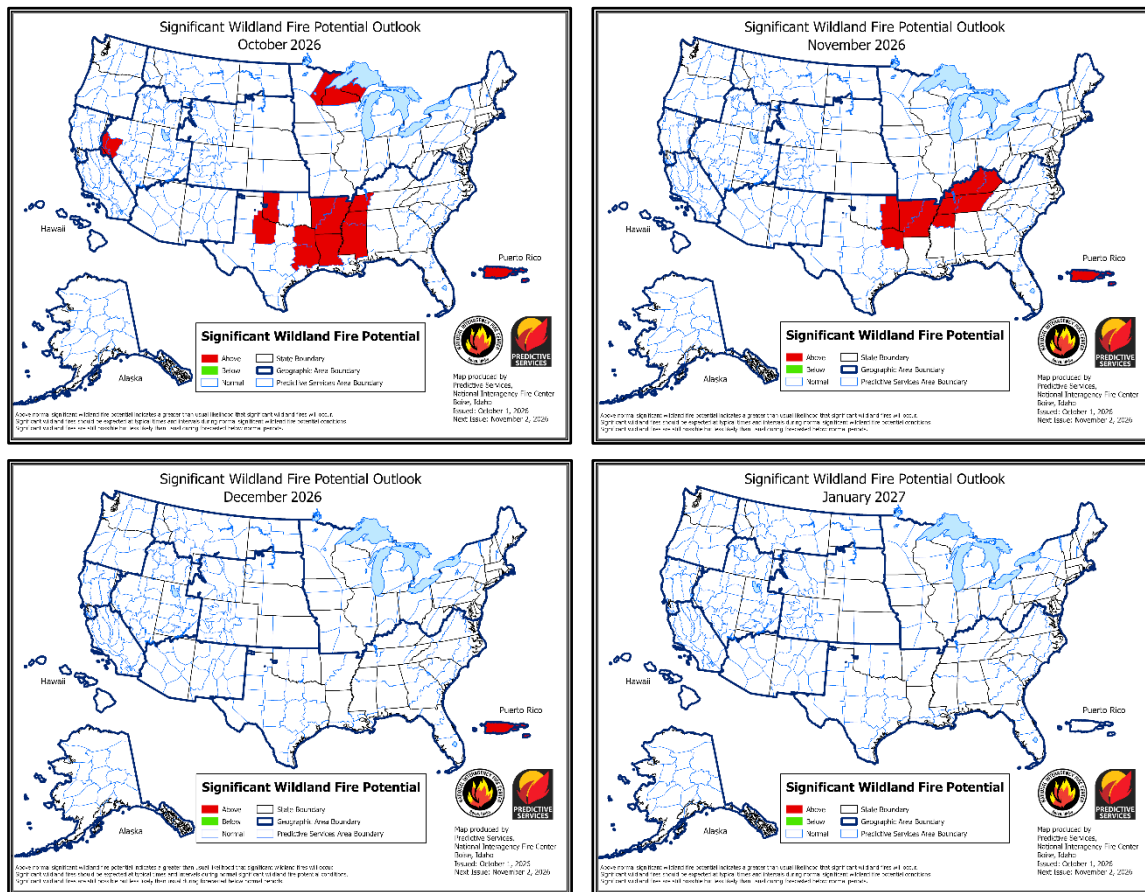


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Outlook Period – October 2026 through January 2027

Executive Summary

The significant wildland fire potential forecasts included in this outlook represent the cumulative forecasts of the ten Geographic Area Predictive Services units and the National Predictive Services unit.



Fire activity diminished quickly during September, with only California and the Southern Area remaining moderately active at the end of the month. As a result of the rapidly diminishing fire activity, the National Preparedness Level dropped from five to four (on a scale of 1-5) September 4, to three September 9, and two September 22. As of September 30, 8,604,892 acres have burned across the country, which is 141% of the previous 10-year average. So far this year 62,369 wildfires have been reported, also above average, at 134%.

September precipitation was above normal for northern California and most of the Northwest eastward into Montana. Precipitation was also above normal for much of the Southwest into the central and northern Plains as well as a small portion of southern California. Precipitation was below normal for central California into Nevada, as well as much of the southern Plains into the Southeast. Overall drought continued to slowly expand the past month, with drought now covering more than 59% of the country. Drought developed and/or intensified in much of the southern

Plains into the Southeast and northern New England. Drought improvement was noted in Florida, as well as portions of the Rockies and northern Plains into Minnesota.

Climate Prediction Center and Predictive Services outlooks issued in late September forecast temperatures that are likely to be above normal across much of the West into the northern and central Plains in October, with temperatures near normal in the Northeast. Below-normal precipitation is likely in most of the West into the northern and central Plains and Great Lakes, with above-normal precipitation in the southern Plains and Southeast due to a very wet start to the month. The following three months from November to January are likely to be warmer-than-normal for the northern tier of the country and Alaska, with no favored outcome for the southern half of the country, but likely to lean near normal. Precipitation is likely to be above normal in the southern tier of the U.S., especially in the Southeast, but potentially drier than normal in the northern Rockies and portions of the Great Lakes.

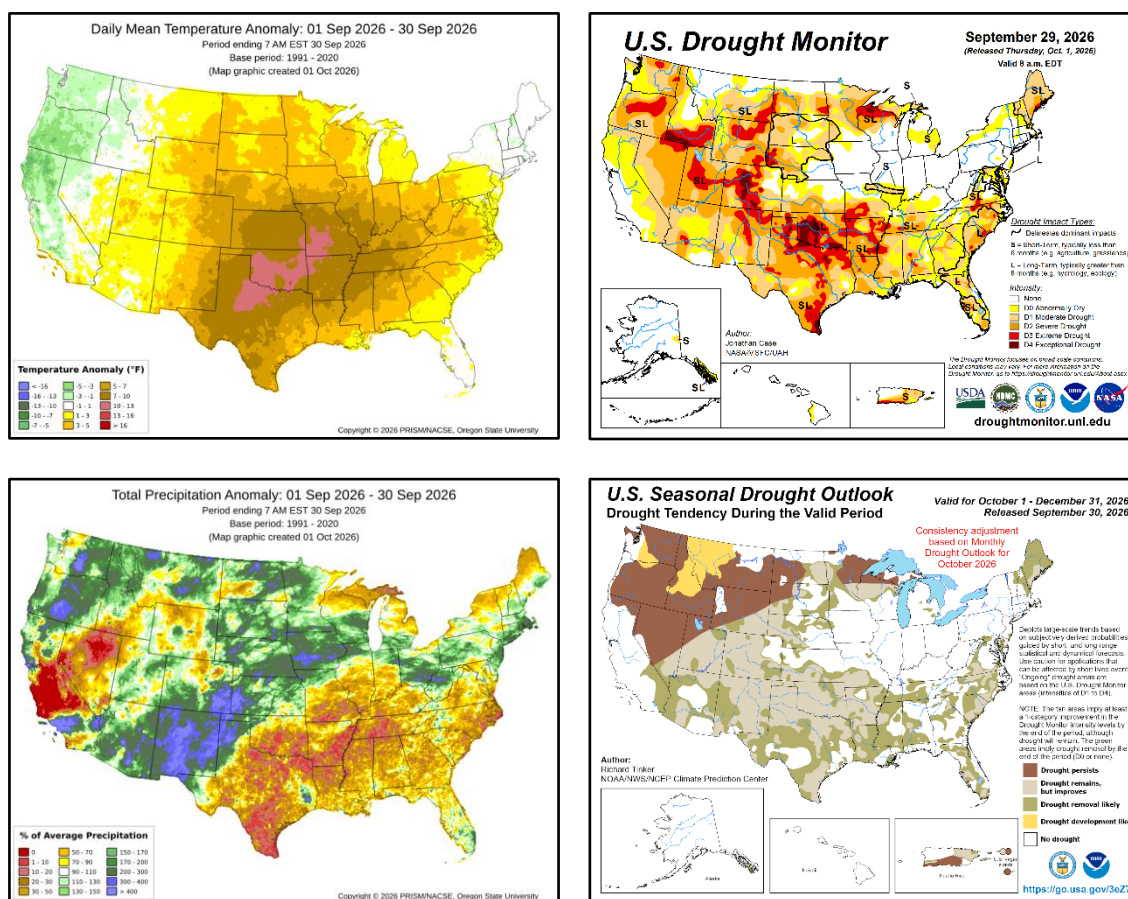
From the current and past weather, as well as forecast conditions, October significant fire potential will remain above normal in portions of north Texas and western Oklahoma. Above normal potential is also forecast for much of east Texas into the Lower Mississippi Valley, northeast Minnesota, northern Wisconsin, western Upper Michigan, Puerto Rico, and the U.S. Virgin Islands. For November, significant fire potential will be normal for most of the country except for portions of east Texas and eastern Oklahoma eastward into most of Kentucky and Tennessee as well as Puerto Rico and the U.S. Virgin Islands. Significant fire potential will be normal for the contiguous U.S. and Alaska for December but will remain above normal for Puerto Rico and the U.S. Virgin Islands. Normal significant fire potential is forecast across the country for January.

Past Weather and Drought

Temperatures in September were below normal along the West Coast into portions of the northern Rockies, but above normal from the Rockies to the Appalachians, with near normal temperatures in the Northeast and Florida. The greatest warm anomalies were observed in the southern Plains to Mid-Mississippi Valley where many areas observed temperatures 7–13°F above average. Near normal temperatures were observed in the northern Plains and Midwest. Temperatures in Alaska and Hawai'i were near to slightly above normal.

Precipitation in September was below normal for most of the southern Plains eastward into the Carolinas and Southeast. Below-normal precipitation also occurred from central California into Nevada and across the Upper Great Lakes and northern New England. Above-normal precipitation occurred across most of northern California into the Northwest, northern Idaho, and Montana. Precipitation was also above normal for a portion of southern California and from much of the Southwest north and eastward into the central and northern Plains. Above-normal precipitation occurred in the lower Great Lakes eastward into southern New England, as well. Precipitation in Alaska was above normal in much of the Interior and southwest Alaska but below normal for south-central Alaska. Hawai'i observed well-above-normal precipitation focused on Kauai and the Big Island, mostly due the passage of Hurricane Lowell near Kauai at the beginning of the month and Hurricane Nolo near the Big Island at the end of the month.

A potent early-season storm moved into the northwestern U.S. at the beginning of September with widespread rainfall across northern California, the Northwest, and northern Rockies. This storm substantially reduced fire activity, and fire activity continued to diminish across the northwestern U.S. the remainder of the month as subsequent, but weaker, storms continued the cool temperatures with periods of light precipitation. Very wet conditions were observed across the Southwest, especially New Mexico, as the Albuquerque airport recorded its wettest ever September with 4.49 inches recorded during the month. However, very hot and dry conditions persisted in the southern Plains and Lower Mississippi Valley most of the month with temperatures up to 105°F into mid-September, and fire activity remained elevated as several large fires emerged on a nearly daily basis.



Left: Departure from Normal Temperature (top) and Percent of Normal Precipitation (bottom) (from *PRISM Climate Group, Oregon State University*). Right: U.S. Drought Monitor (top) and Seasonal Drought Outlook (bottom) (from *National Drought Mitigation Center and the Climate Prediction Center*).

Overall drought increased in September, with over 59% of the country in drought as of September 29. Drought continued to develop and expand in the southern Plains and Lower Mississippi Valley. Drought also developed and/or intensified in portions of the southern Sierra, Mid-Mississippi Valley, Upper Great Lakes, northern New England, and Southeast. Drought improved over the past month in portions of the Rockies, Northwest, northern Plains, northern Minnesota, and Florida. Areas of extreme to exceptional drought remained nearly the same with around 12% of the country in these categories. Extreme to exceptional drought is most widespread across central Oregon, southern Idaho, central Utah, central Rockies, Texas Panhandle, and western Oklahoma. Smaller areas of extreme drought are noted in the Dakotas, northern Wisconsin, Arkansas, and portions of the southeast Atlantic coast. Exceptional drought is observed in portions of Oregon, Idaho, Nevada, Colorado, New Mexico, Texas, Oklahoma, Nebraska, and Arkansas.

Drought is expected to improve in many areas of the country in the next three months, most notably in the southern half of the West into the southern Plains. Drought is also expected to improve in the Southeast and northern New England. Drought is most likely to persist and/or expand in the Northwest, northern Rockies, and portions of the Upper Midwest.

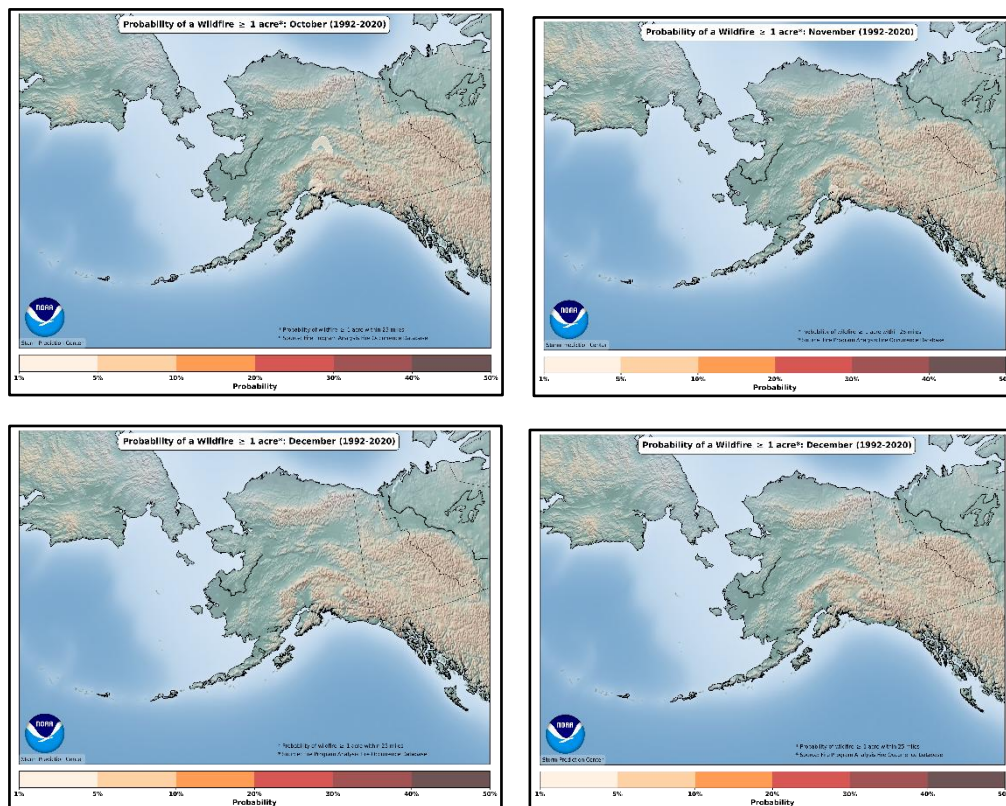
Weather and Climate Outlooks

El Niño continues to rapidly strengthen in the equatorial Pacific Ocean. Central Tropical Pacific sea surface temperature anomalies are more than 2 C above average, the threshold for a very strong El Niño. El Niño is forecast to continue to strengthen through the fall by the Climate Prediction Center (CPC), with a greater than 95% chance of a very strong El Niño continuing into

the winter. In fact, most of the models used by the CPC and internationally show this El Niño to be the strongest on record, and the CPC forecasts a 75% chance that the strength would exceed the previous strongest El Niño since 1950.

The Pacific Decadal Oscillation (PDO) remains in a weakly negative phase and is likely to remain negative through the outlook period. The Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO) was generally weak in September except for some recent enhanced activity in the western hemisphere. The MJO is forecast to remain weak into the winter, and its impact is often significantly less during an El Niño. Therefore, the main climate driver for the outlook will be the very strong El Niño.

Geographic Area Forecasts



Normal fire season progression across Alaska shown by the probability of a fire greater than 1 acre within 25 miles. Fire severity cannot be inferred from this analysis. Note that December is shown twice as January's climatology matches December's. (Based on 1992-2020 FPA Data. Analysis courtesy of the Storm Prediction Center.)

Alaska

Normal fire potential is expected for Alaska over the next four months. For practical purposes, Alaska is out of fire season as temperatures drop below freezing and the persisting wet fall pattern continues. Although there remains some potential for new ignitions in the southeastern Interior where rainfall has been scarce, the shortening daylight and lower sun angle will maintain low fire potential.

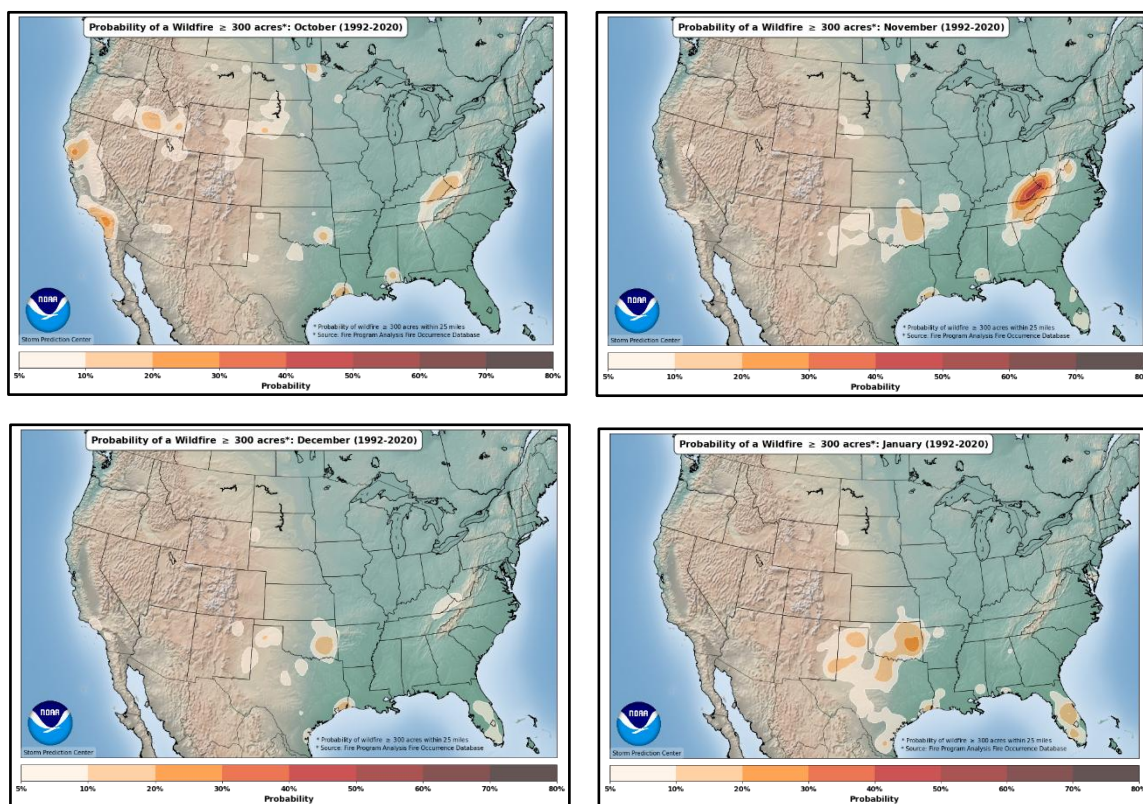
The most recent update to the U.S. Drought Monitor shows an area classified as abnormally dry over a portion of the southeastern Interior. Abnormally dry to moderate drought are identified over the panhandle. Based on fire weather indices and firsthand reports, the only area with any late-season potential remains the Upper Tanana Valley near Tok and a small portion of the Copper River Basin. Though these areas have been extremely dry, temperatures and relative humidity are moderating such that fire activity has been minimal.

Climate Prediction Center outlooks for October indicate that conditions are likely to be warmer and wetter in the east, while slightly cooler and drier in the west. However, October is the month when below-freezing temperatures become widespread, and relative humidity is too high to support fire spread regardless of precipitation.

Fire behavior was limited during September, which is typical for fall. Most ignitions occurred in southern Alaska, and all remained small and were quickly contained.

A near-record wet September kept fire weather indices at low levels for all fuel layers and types in most areas. In the southeastern Interior, from Fortymile Country south to Tok and the Copper River Basin, duff fuels remain moderately dry. However, concerns have diminished due to cooler, wetter weather and several light rain showers.

Fire activity is expected to be near normal from October through January as Alaska moves into winter. Early October may see a few human-caused ignitions that should be easily contained barring a significant wind event. By mid-October, snow will move into most Interior locations and will push south of the Alaska Range into south-central Alaska and the Copper River Basin by early November, effectively ending the fire year.



Normal fire season progression across the contiguous U.S. shown by the probability of a fire greater than 300 acres within 25 miles. Fire severity cannot be inferred from this analysis. (Based on 1992-2020 FPA Data. Analysis courtesy of the Storm Prediction Center.)

Northwest

Significant fire potential is expected to remain normal across all Northwest Geographic Area Predictive Services Areas (PSA) in October. Periods of warm, dry weather and offshore flow are possible, especially early in the month, and may briefly increase fire potential where fuels remain receptive. However, the seasonal transition toward higher relative humidity, shorter burn periods,

and more frequent cool season systems should limit opportunities for significant fire growth. Accordingly, normal significant fire potential is expected to continue through January.

September marked a clear shift from the hot, dry conditions of August. Temperatures were generally below normal across Oregon and Washington. Much of Oregon ran about 2–4°F below normal, with localized areas 4–6°F below normal, while Washington was generally near normal to about 2°F below normal. Precipitation was well above normal across most of Oregon and central and eastern Washington, many areas received 200–400% of normal, even though normal daily precipitation amounts are very low at this time of year. Western Washington, including the northern Cascades, was considerably drier, with many areas receiving only 50–75% of normal precipitation and some receiving 25% or less.

Despite September's moisture, drought remained firmly established across much of the geographic area. Severe drought persisted across portions of central and eastern Washington, while extreme drought developed in parts of central Washington. In Oregon, extreme and exceptional drought continued across portions of central, south-central, and southeastern Oregon. September precipitation provided short term improvement in fuel moisture, but longer-term moisture deficits remain. Water year precipitation was still below normal across considerable portions of Oregon, while water year temperatures remained above normal across nearly the entire geographic area.

Fire activity slowed significantly in September after several rounds of precipitation reduced fire growth, and the number of new ignitions remained low. Substantial progress toward containment was made on the large fires that have been burning since mid-July. However, fires in the Cascades of north central Washington did not receive the same moisture as other areas and remained active when weather conditions aligned with fuels and topography. Decreases in day length and sun angle are now limiting the burn period, further reducing the potential for fire spread.

Energy Release Component (ERC) values dropped across the Northwest at the beginning of September and remained average to below average until drier weather late in the month caused them to rise again. Seasonality is limiting how much drying can occur, but underlying seasonal drought persists despite recent rainfall.

The El Niño continues to strengthen, with the Climate Prediction Center (CPC) indicating a greater than 95% chance of a very strong El Niño during fall and winter. The June–August Relative Oceanic Niño Index was 1.4 C, and El Niño is expected to persist through winter and into spring. While El Niño will increasingly influence the seasonal pattern, October fire weather will still depend largely on regional ridging and troughing, frontal passages, and onshore or offshore flow.

The outlook from CPC shows equal chances for either above or below normal temperatures across Oregon and Washington for October, followed by above normal temperatures for November–January. Upper-level ridging is favored during early October, with warmer conditions likely when the ridge axis is over the region. When the ridge axis shifts west of the Cascades or offshore, easterly flow may bring additional warming west of the Cascades. While cooler systems will periodically interrupt the pattern, the seasonal outlook favors a warmer than normal background later in the four-month period.

Northern California and Hawai'i

Significant fire potential is projected to be normal from October through January in northern California. During October, four large fires are typically observed across Northern California, followed by one in November, and less than one on average from December through January. Hawaii's significant fire potential is expected to remain normal October through January.

September weather patterns were mixed in northern California. Upper-level troughs created unsettled weather periods, most evident at the beginning and end of the month, while drier, warmer ridging was dominant during the second and third weeks of the month. An unusually moist and cool period occurred across the region September 1–6, resulting in near to below normal average monthly temperatures and near to above normal precipitation across most of the area. There were nine thunderstorm days that amounted to 608 lightning strikes. The 2000–2025 lightning average for September is 4,400; therefore, strike counts were well below average. Red Flag Warnings were issued by the National Weather Service on six separate days due to dry, gusty, mainly onshore wind events, below the monthly average of 8.3. High-risk significant fire potential was issued by Predictive Services on two separate days due to gusty, dry wind events. The strongest northerly wind event occurred September 13-14, favoring the Sacramento Valley and adjacent foothills.

Dead fuel moisture experienced a noticeable improvement during the first week of September due to the extended unsettled weather pattern. By mid-September, regional Energy Release Component (ERC) values reverted upward to seasonally flammable levels and remained that way for most of the month. Live fuels continued to cure across all elevations in September, and many woody shrub species entered peak flammability. Sampled fuel moisture readings were generally near normal, with some Predictive Services Areas (PSAs) slightly above while others were slightly below normal on average. Herbaceous fuels were generally cured or mostly cured across all elevations due to seasonality and high-elevation freezing.

Areas of drought experienced some modifications between late August and late September, with moderate drought found mainly across the Northwest Mountains, Northeast California, and Far Eastside PSAs. The two-month Evaporative Demand Drought Index (EDDI) values on September 27 indicated near- to below-normal vegetative stress across the area.

Wildfire business decreased in northern California during September compared to August. The daily wildfire ignition average through September 28 was 8.8, while the August average was 14.6. September 2008–2025 daily ignition average is 15.1. A total of two large fires had been reported through September 28. None of the large fires required a Complex Incident Management Team (CMT) to manage them, although the Lucas Fire, located in the Clear Lake area, needed a Type 3 team. The regional preparedness level dropped from three to two (on a scale of 1–5) on September 21. Prescribed burning increased following the early September wet period, with several broadcast burns implemented across many fuel types.

There will be several coupled ocean and atmospheric states in play during the next several months, but the very strong El Niño is expected to be the main player for regional weather patterns. October is expected to be warmer and drier than normal, while November through January are likely to be wetter overall. November is likely to be the transition month. Mixed temperature anomalies will likely coincide with the November through January period. The number of wind events should be near normal, with the best chance for breezy and dry northerly wind events during October.

Based on the current fuel state and future weather predictions, normal significant fire potential is projected for October through January in northern California. October has the best potential for the fire environment to support notable fire growth due to the anticipated warmer and drier pattern, although there is less confidence in unusual amounts of breezy and dry wind and/or lightning events. There are likely to be fewer alignments in critically flammable live and dead fuels following October due to seasonality and the weather pattern becoming wetter. Noticeable lower elevation green-up should effectively end the fire season sometime during November and December.

Sea surface temperature (SST) anomalies surrounding the Hawai'ian Islands were near normal on average during September. Two tropical systems impacted the island chain during the month. Hurricane Lowell brought significant winds and rainfall to Kauai while Hurricane Nolo provided similar results to the Big Island. The entire island chain was impacted by the hurricanes in some

fashion. Precipitation during September was above to well above normal across most of the island chain, although some drier than normal areas showed up across central portions which were less affected by the hurricanes. Temperature anomalies were mixed but generally near to above normal, except for Kauai, which trended a little cooler than normal. Drought was not found across the island chain, and the abnormally dry area on the U.S. Drought Monitor shrank between late August and late September. As a result of an active tropical season, herbaceous fuels were generally greener than normal, although some areas were in a mixed phase. The largest reported fire during the month occurred on Maui, with an estimated 100 acres of grass burning due to downslope winds from Nolo on September 26. No Red Flag Warnings were issued by the National Weather Service in September for Hawai'i.

The El Niño-Southern Oscillation (ENSO) is in an El Niño state, will continue to strengthen, and become very strong the next four months. Temperature anomalies in Hawai'i will likely start out warmer than normal, then become more mixed later in the forecast period. October and November should be the transition months, with above-normal precipitation favoring the southern tier of islands, then trending more below normal across the island chain during December and January. This drier expectation creates some concern later in the forecast period, with abundant herbaceous fuels likely experiencing more curing across the leeward sides. Additionally, some islands will likely have significantly cured surface debris left over from the active tropical season. Nonetheless, normal significant fire potential is projected for Hawai'i for the four-month outlook period, and drought influences will be reassessed later in the forecast period.

Southern California

Temperatures in central and southern California were variable in September, with a brief but intense period of heat early in the month followed by fluctuating temperatures and a couple periods of early-season coolness. This left the monthly average near to slightly below normal in most areas. A notable exception was in coastal areas, where much warmer-than-normal offshore waters contributed to continued warmth over adjacent land. The most notable weather event of the month was an unusual rain episode over southern California during Labor Day weekend, associated with moisture from Hurricane Marie. This led to well-above-normal rainfall across a large portion of southern California. After that event, little rainfall occurred for the remainder of the month, as a series of mostly dry and weak Pacific troughs brought no more than isolated showers and thunderstorms while keeping the monsoon east of the region. Onshore flow prevailed throughout the month, with a few periods of gusty winds across the eastern Sierra and the deserts, but no major wind events arose. The eastern Pacific tropics remained highly active throughout the month, but only fringe effects were observed from several systems.

The latest U.S. Drought Monitor shows little in the way of drought over central and southern California, with just some moderate drought over the southern California deserts. Abnormally dry conditions persist across much of interior California. This is largely a result of rainfall deficits and anomalous heat this past winter and early spring, with a relatively weak monsoon this summer unable to alleviate those conditions.

Rainfall early in the month and subsequent cool conditions have kept heavier dead fuel moisture near to above normal and well above critical levels over the past few weeks. This further contributes to this year's pattern of near- to below-normal fire danger for much of the fire season. Notably, aside from a couple of brief spikes, most of the peak fire season has seen below-normal Energy Release Component (ERC) values, reflecting a lack of sustained hot and dry periods over the summer.

Rainfall from Marie caused a considerable spike in live fuel moisture (LFM) levels over parts of southern California, which will yield reduced flammability over those areas this fall. Areas that did not receive much rain from Marie are still seeing LFM readings at or near critical levels due to the lack of any meaningful rainfall, with the potential for live fuels to remain a major factor in fire spread.

A strong to near-record-strength El Niño event is in progress across the equatorial Pacific. This event is likely to peak in the next two to three months, and indications are that very strong El Niño conditions will be in place through this winter. Very warm SST anomalies also extend from the California coast southward, and across broad swaths of the mid and higher latitudes of the Pacific.

Heading into fall and early winter, offshore winds become the primary driver of fire activity. Offshore wind events occurring ahead of seasonal rainfall can produce some of the region's largest and most destructive fires. Medium-range models suggest a period of much warmer-than-normal temperatures through the first half of October, along with some potential for offshore winds, indicating potential for significant fire activity. However, portions of southern California, including areas most susceptible to offshore winds, experienced significant rainfall from moisture associated with Hurricane Marie. While not sufficient to induce broad-scale green-up, noteworthy increases in LFM and soil moisture occurred across a sizable portion of southern California. In addition, strong El Niño conditions and climate-model projections favor above-normal precipitation this fall and winter, especially from December onward. Despite the looming warmth of early October, the broader cool-season pattern is expected to favor frequent troughs moving in from the Pacific rather than dropping south over interior North America. This pattern typically results in a below normal number of Santa Ana wind events, even if a couple occur early in the season. Were it not for the upcoming warmth, below-normal significant fire potential would likely be warranted for the South Coast Predictive Services Area for October due to the lingering benefits of the rainfall from Marie. However, considering the shorter-term forecast, near-normal potential remains warranted, implying potential for some fire activity. Above-normal potential was considered for portions of central California, but upcoming concerns appear limited and transient enough to preclude that need. Beyond the mixed but likely inconsequential signals for October, near-normal significant potential is indicated for all areas by November through January, months in which little fire activity is typical and by which time widespread significant rainfall is expected. As always, some potential for fire activity remains until a widespread significant rain event occurs.

Northern Rockies

The significant fire potential outlook for October through January for the Northern Rockies Geographic Area (NRGA) will be normal for all areas. Multiple precipitation events in September mitigated most dryness concerns. By the end of the month, wildfire activity gave way to prescribed fire. Moisture in many areas provides a buffer that will likely persist into October. Wind events remain a concern as the month progresses, but through mid-October a pattern of high-frequency, low-amplitude disturbances should prevent very strong wind events from developing.

September was unusually wet, with much of the NRGA receiving more than 150% of normal precipitation. Precipitation occurred in three windows and emphasized different areas. An event September 5–8 brought moisture to the western and northern parts of the NRGA. A second notable pattern occurred September 18–19, with greater precipitation in central and southern Montana. Finally, late-month rounds of wet thunderstorms affected eastern North Dakota. Portions of the NRGA reporting below-normal September precipitation include a strip of southern Montana along the Wyoming border and southwest and south-central North Dakota. Temperatures in September were slightly below normal west of the Continental Divide and slightly above normal east of the Divide. The U.S. Drought Monitor showed improvement across about half of the NRGA, with only a minor increase in drought in southeast North Dakota.

Only southern Montana reported large fire activity in September. The fires occurred in two windows, with the first driven by a warm and windy episode early in the month. The Rattlesnake Complex emerged September 2–4 in eastern Montana as lightning started multiple fires that were followed by windy days with temperatures of 85–95°F. A second strong wind event mid-month

produced the largest fire. The Davis Coulee Fire in Big Horn County reached 15,000 acres as winds gusted to 45 mph over a six-hour period on September 14. The September 18–19 precipitation event curtailed nearly all fire activity, and windows for prescribed fire began to be utilized.

October is expected to start dry and warm across much of the NRGAs, but recent precipitation and a lack of early freezes have kept many grasses alive, limiting concerns. When fuels dry later in the month, burn windows will be noticeably shorter due to the lack of daylight. It is possible the remainder of the month could see little precipitation, but extended model guidance shows a fast-moving pattern across the northern tier of the CONUS, which should limit the duration of high-wind events for a few weeks. Fire activity becomes minimal across the NRGAs from November through January, but rangeland fires associated with high winds are possible nearly any time of year.

Great Basin

An increase in wildfire activity is anticipated across the drier areas of western Nevada during the first half of October, primarily from small fires as any large fires would likely require prolonged, strong winds. Areas farther north and east are not expected to experience significant fire activity for the remainder of the season. Otherwise, all areas are expected to see wildfire activity diminish to normal off-season levels from late October onward, largely due to longer nights and shorter daytime burn periods.

Temperatures over the last 30 days have been near normal across western areas of the Great Basin, and 2–5°F above normal in eastern areas. Precipitation was 125–200% of normal across northern and eastern areas, but less than 25% of normal across much of western Nevada. The U.S. Drought Monitor has most southern and central areas in severe to extreme drought, with portions of southwest Idaho and northeast Nevada in exceptional drought.

Fuels have moistened significantly, with fuel moisture values increasing to near the 50th percentile across the eastern Great Basin, including most of Utah, southeast Nevada, western Wyoming, and adjacent eastern Idaho. These levels are unlikely to return to near-critical thresholds this season. Valleys in eastern and southern areas that saw abundant rainfall in recent weeks have begun getting new grass growth in the lower elevations. However, the western half of Nevada and far southwest Idaho have not had wetting rain in the past 3–5 weeks, resulting in above-normal Energy Release Component (ERC) values, approaching the 80th percentile, in much of that region. Live fuel moisture levels across western Nevada are still 60–90% at most stations, which correlates with extreme fire behavior. In addition, across parts of northern Nevada and southern Idaho, there are areas of above-normal carryover fuels from the past two years. With prolonged very warm and dry conditions in the first two weeks of October, ERC could return to near the 90th percentile by mid-October. Otherwise, expectations are for fuels remain at noncritical levels in all areas despite the warming and drying the first half of October.

Wildfire activity remained very active at the start of September in the Great Basin, but waves of mid- to late-month rain moistened fuels considerably in most areas. That, along with the rapidly shortening daytime burn periods and longer nights, brought all large incidents to an end by the last week of September as the Great Basin dropped from preparedness level four (on a scale of 1–5) to one as the month progressed. However, far western areas of Nevada received little rainfall the past month and have not had wetting rain since mid-August, with a prolonged very warm and dry period expected for early to mid-October.

Most of the Great Basin's fire weather concerns will be in October. Medium-range models have been in agreement recently, building the strongest and potentially longest-lasting area of high-pressure since late March. Due to the lack of recent rain over far western areas of the Great Basin, and with fuels already drier than normal, above normal significant fire potential is forecast

for the Sierra Front and adjacent Lahontan Basin for October. Other areas and all other months should remain normal, especially with the record strong El Niño likely to bring wet weather conditions later this year.

Southwest

For the Southwest area, September wraps up with areas along and east of the Continental Divide finishing with well-above-normal precipitation thanks to a late-season monsoon push the second half of the month. Arizona missed much of this moisture and had precipitation that was near to slightly above normal. Temperatures stayed above normal regionwide, with Arizona running up to 3°F above average and New Mexico even warmer, with many areas 3–9°F above normal. Wildfire activity persisted early in the month, but the late-month moisture greatly reduced activity on ongoing fires. Energy Release Component (ERC) values, which were near record highs at the start of September, dropped to record lows by the end of the month.

Moving into October, the pattern favors near- to above-normal temperatures and limited chances for meaningful rainfall. Long-range guidance shows expanding dryness across the Southwest, with below-normal precipitation expected unless late-season tropical remnants drift into the region, features that are difficult to predict but could still briefly boost moisture. Warm afternoons and dry air help cure fine fuels and slow early-season recovery, and despite shortening daylight, the combination of lingering heat and lack of widespread rainfall keeps conditions somewhat prime for Arizona.

November maintains this drier trend, with near- to below-normal precipitation favored in both Arizona and New Mexico. Arizona remains notably warm, while eastern New Mexico sees slight cooling from early fronts that remain mostly fast-moving and dry. At the broader climate scale, the forecast continues to align with a record-strength El Niño, which typically enhances winter moisture and snowpack across the Southwest. However, a negative Pacific Decadal Oscillation (PDO) is also in place, and that can counteract some of El Niño's influence, meaning precipitation amounts may end up closer to normal rather than substantially above average along with warmer temperatures. Fine fuels may see modest seasonal moderation, but long-term drought signals persist, and Arizona's continued warmth still supports occasional elevated fire activity.

December brings a mixed moisture signal with dryness holding over New Mexico, while western Arizona sees periodic attempts at moisture pushing in from the southwest, though the eastward extent remains uncertain. Temperatures stay near to slightly above normal, which could delay early snowpack development and increase the likelihood of rain instead of snow during initial winter systems. Fire potential remains seasonally low, though warm and breezy periods may still allow isolated activity.

January finally shows clearer signs of a slightly cooler, wetter pattern beginning to take shape. Storm tracks may start to shift south enough to bring more consistent moisture and improved opportunities for snowpack and early-season fuel recovery. While the El Niño-PDO interplay still tempers expectations, January appears to offer the best chance so far for meaningful winter systems. Fire potential remains low and may decrease further if this transition toward cooler, wetter conditions continues. Despite the likelihood of warmer and drier than normal conditions for some areas this fall, significant fire potential is expected to remain normal through January.

Rocky Mountain

September brought more storm systems through the Rocky Mountain Area (RMA), leading to above-normal rain across most of the area. Temperatures remained above average, and Kansas saw significant heat. The rain brought some improvement to drought conditions across Colorado and Wyoming, while drought increased in Kansas due to the hot temperatures. Moving into fall

and winter, strong El Niño conditions will persist, bringing more favorable weather and normal significant fire potential across the RMA.

The monsoon pattern associated with a southwestern U.S. high-pressure ridge gave way to more regular low-pressure systems in September. With these storms, much of the RMA was near to above normal for precipitation during the month. Some of the highest elevations picked up a light dusting of snow, although any snow melted quickly. Temperatures were still above average across the RMA, though northwest Wyoming was only slightly above average. Southeast Kansas exceeded 10°F above average as strong high pressure sat over the southern Plains for the first half of the month. Despite the elevated temperatures, the rain maintained the current drought or began to improve conditions. However, eastern Kansas saw developing drought during the month as the heat led to significant drying despite the periods of rainfall.

Precipitation across much of the RMA in September kept fuel moisture moderated at most elevations. Above-average temperatures across most of the area led to fire danger indices increasing during periods of limited precipitation, but indices did not remain critical for extended periods. Fuels continued to be receptive to lightning ignitions but were not conducive to rapid fire growth. Live fuel moisture began to trend up with the regular rain in August that continued in September, and overall fire danger continued to trend down throughout the month. Fuels curing and dormancy has been slowed by the above-average moisture.

The RMA saw many lightning fires in September that were not confined to a particular part of the area. Many of these new ignitions remained small and did not require significant resource mobilization. A few fires in the first week of September grew to over 1,000 acres but remained at the Type 3 management level.

In the short term, routine rounds of precipitation will continue to moderate conditions. Fall typically sees increasing storm systems with stronger winds moving into the RMA. The ongoing El Niño, characterized by warmer water in the central Pacific Ocean, is expected to peak in the November–December timeframe. This will likely become a very strong El Niño, reaching at least 3 C above average. A typical fall and winter during El Niño conditions brings wetter weather with normal temperatures to the southern tier of the RMA, generally south of Interstate 70. The northern portions of the RMA typically see warmer conditions and average precipitation. The expected weather conditions during this El Niño will also lead to improving drought conditions across the RMA.

Weather conditions going into October will support continued favorable fire weather, as will the developing very strong El Niño through the remainder of the outlook period. Across the RMA, the significant fire potential will be normal October to January. However, due to the potential for increased wind events in the fall and winter, brief periods of elevated fire potential may occur, particularly following stretches of warm, dry weather. These elevated conditions are expected to be short-lived, generally lasting no more than one or two operational periods.

Eastern Area

Normal significant fire potential is forecast for most of the Eastern Area through January. However, above-normal potential is forecast for northeastern Minnesota, northern Wisconsin, and the western Upper Peninsula of Michigan in October. This is due to a combination of drought already on the landscape and continued dryness forecasted through at least mid-October.

In the Midwest and Great Lakes, abnormal dryness and moderate drought are currently present in much of Minnesota and Wisconsin, the Upper Peninsula of Michigan, the central Lower Peninsula, northwestern Iowa, and southern Missouri. Severe drought is present in Minnesota, northern Wisconsin, the western Upper Peninsula, and southern Missouri. Extreme drought is present along the edges of Minnesota, northern Wisconsin, and southern Missouri. In a small

area of north-central Wisconsin, exceptional drought is present in Douglas, Bayfield, Ashland, and Iron counties. Along the East Coast, moderate drought covers most of Maryland and Delaware in the south, and from Cape Cod to the northern border of Maine in the north. Parts of upstate New York and southern New Jersey are abnormally dry.

In September, temperatures were above normal across most of the Eastern Area, ranging from less than 1°F above normal around much of the Great Lakes region to over 10°F above normal in southern Missouri. In contrast, the Northeast was about 1°F below normal.

Much of the Eastern Area received normal to above-normal precipitation in the last month, but three regions were drier than normal. Upstate New York, Vermont, New Hampshire, and Maine received about 50% of normal precipitation. Southern Missouri, southern Illinois, and southern Indiana received about 25% of normal precipitation. Finally, northern Wisconsin and the Upper Peninsula of Michigan received around 20% of normal precipitation.

Changes in drought severity closely followed these precipitation patterns. Drought improved by up to two levels in western Iowa, southern Wisconsin, and eastern Pennsylvania, and by one level in Minnesota and southern Michigan. At the same time, drought increased by up to three levels in southern Missouri, by up to two levels in Maine and New Hampshire, and by one level in portions of Minnesota, Wisconsin, Michigan, Illinois, New York, and Vermont.

Periods of increased initial attack across multiple states continued in drought areas of the Eastern Area during September, with live fuel stress and periods of hot, dry, windy events. The large fires in the Minnesota Arrowhead have received enough consistent precipitation to reduce the risk of reburn as dry, fall conditions are predicted for that area. Areas of extensive drought can expect periods of increased initial attack and extended mop-up during this outlook period, as fall dormancy and leaf and needle drop add to surface fuels and spread potential. The entire Eastern Area will transition during this outlook period from a live fuel system to a dead fuel system with normal fall wildfire activity. Periods of increased wildfire activity will occur in areas that do not receive long-duration soaking rains from frontal systems or at least frequent short-duration rains that maintain wet surface fuels.

The Climate Prediction Center (CPC) forecasts above-normal temperatures for the entire Eastern Area for October and above-normal temperatures for all the Eastern Area except for far southwestern Missouri through December. Normal precipitation is forecast for the entire Eastern Area for October. Through December, the CPC outlook shows below-normal precipitation around the Great Lakes, and above-normal precipitation to the south in Iowa, Missouri, Maryland, Delaware, and New Jersey.

Long-term models forecast drier-than-normal conditions continuing throughout October, November, December, and January from northern Minnesota east to Michigan. Drier conditions are also shown in Maine in October, but otherwise wetter-than-normal conditions are forecast for eastern and southern portions of the Eastern Area through the outlook period as the strengthening El Niño brings higher precipitation amounts to the southern U.S.

As a result, above-normal fire potential is forecast to continue in October for the Predictive Services Areas (PSAs) encompassing northern Minnesota, northern Wisconsin, and the western Upper Peninsula of Michigan (i.e. PSAs EA03 and EA04). Cooling temperatures and moderating conditions will bring fire potential back to seasonal norms for November, December, and January. For the remainder of the region, normal significant fire potential is forecast through January.

Southern Area

September was historically hot and dry over western and central portions of the geographic area, capping off a summer of flash drought that exacerbated long-term dryness in some areas. Impacts

to the landscape were quite evident, with marginal weather conditions required to produce significant fires where drought stressed woody fuels and cured this year's herbaceous growth. Meanwhile, drought has persisted for over a year across portions of the Southeast, where El Niño's winter rains cannot come soon enough. Most Southern Area states have reported longer-than-normal mop up and an unusually high number of lightning-ignited fires that can be attributed to underlying drought. In the Caribbean, September saw some relief over Puerto Rico, but extreme drought continues to plague the fire-prone southern portions of the main island. Extreme and locally exceptional drought dominates the U.S. Virgin Islands, with no relief in sight.

Beneficial moisture to begin October may have long-lasting impacts in portions of the Plains, Gulf Coast, and Florida peninsula. Cool season grasses are likely to green up where the heaviest rain occurs in Texas and Oklahoma, mitigating fire activity until hard freezes occur later this winter. Central and southwest Texas observed two years of robust herbaceous fuel growth due to flooding in July 2025 and July 2026, and these areas will have to be watched closely through the dormant season due to the above normal grass loading.

Early leaf drop and needle cast have been reported due to drought across some areas in the eastern Plains states, Mississippi Valley, and Southeast. This may be traced back to the historically dry and hot weather during spring green-up, compounded by impacts from late summer heat, as freezing temperatures have yet to occur. Another potential but uncertain impact to the landscape this fall could occur in pine-dominant areas that see beetle infestations. Pine mortality may become more evident where trees are especially stressed from this year's drought, particularly in Arkansas and the coastal Carolinas. These conditions will become more obvious in the coming weeks and could be impactful as early as next spring. Fuels from ice storm damage in the Mississippi Valley and Hurricane Helene in the Southeast are especially concerning, with heavier fuels from both events becoming increasingly burnable.

Drought relief will not be as widespread as needed to fully squash fire activity in the western two-thirds of the geographic area. Much drier weather will likely follow the wet start to the month, potentially extending for two to three weeks in many areas. Rainfall patterns in October could begin to show the classic El Niño pattern, with western, southern, and eastern parts of the geographic area seeing frequent precipitation events. Drier periods will be favored in some of the areas with both long- and short-term drought, to include portions of the eastern Plains and Mississippi Valley states. Overall, these wetter conditions will become more likely during winter, and any delay in the return of a wetter pattern could exacerbate drought and fire risks for large parts of the region. The frequency of rainfall events will become especially important once leaf drop occurs in late October and November.

For October, above normal significant fire potential is most likely across western north Texas into western Oklahoma, in addition to east Texas and the Lower Mississippi Valley. Insufficient drought relief followed by accelerated drying in the next few weeks will only allow for a brief reprieve. Heat-driven fire risks are done for the year, but dry cold fronts, potential Gulf tropical activity and overall windier periods with low relative humidity appear likely. Fuel concerns will continue to abound, as well.

Above normal significant fire potential in November is expected from eastern Oklahoma into northeast Texas, Arkansas, north Mississippi, west and middle Tennessee, and Kentucky. No obvious drought relief is anticipated, as these areas are traditionally favored to see drier weather during years with a strong to very strong El Niño. Conditions are less certain for the traditional peak fall fire season in the rest of the southern Appalachians, as a gradient in rainfall is possible. Areas with Helene damage and long-term drought should certainly be monitored closely if drier weather returns and hangs on for extended periods.

Conditions by December into January will trend towards normal, though below normal significant fire potential is possible in some of the areas that can see dormant season fires in the Plains and over south Florida; both are areas that are favored to be wet this winter.

Fire activity is atypical in the Caribbean islands this time of year, but drought continues to be historic, and the region's dry season is just around the corner. With tropical activity unlikely into October and November due to El Niño, drought will remain steady or intensify. Surges of drier air will eventually return, increasing the risk for fire activity this fall and winter. For January, some model guidance predicts that a wetter pattern will encroach on the islands, so normal significant fire potential is forecasted for now.

Outlook Objectives

The National Significant Wildland Fire Potential Outlook is intended as a decision support tool for wildland fire managers, providing an assessment of current weather and fuels conditions and how these will evolve in the next four months. The objective is to assist fire managers in making proactive decisions that will improve protection of life, property, and natural resources, increase fire fighter safety and effectiveness, and reduce firefighting costs.

For questions about this outlook, please contact the National Interagency Coordination Center at (208) 387-5400 or contact your local Geographic Area Predictive Services unit.

Note: Additional Geographic Area assessments may be available at the specific GACC websites. The GACC websites can also be accessed through the NICC webpage at:

<http://www.nifc.gov/nicc/predictive/outlooks/outlooks.htm>